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Beach blanket with sand-fillable bags

Abstract

A beach blanket including a stretchable main panel having two opposite sides comprising a body supporting top side for individuals to sunbath on and a bottom side for resting on a sandy beach surface, and a plurality of invertible bags attached to perimeter of the stretchable main panel. Each bag pivots about the stretchable main panel to allow users to scoop a large quantity of sand within each bag. The sand-filled bags are positioned on the beach to provide opposing tension on the main panel to easily eject sand off the blanket, and to securely anchor the beach blanket onto a beach which also prevents wind from blowing the beach blanket away.

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Background/Summary

FIELD OF THE INVENTION

(1) The present invention relates to a beach anchoring apparatus, and more particularly, to a beach

blanket including attached bags designed for scooping and holding sand therein where the sand-filled bags are positioned on the beach to provide opposing tension on the blanket for ejecting sand from the sunbathing surface.

BACKGROUND OF THE INVENTION

(2) One popular activity that is enjoyed by many during the hot summer months is going to the beach to sunbath in the hot sun and swim in the ocean. In contemplation of going to the beach, individuals typically pack a variety of staples that include food, drinks, snacks, and various beach accessories such as sun screen, coolers, and chairs. An accessory that is often employed while at the beach is a beach blanket or towel. The beach blanket is laid out on the beach in a flat configuration for individuals to rest on. In practice, users typically lay the blanket on the beach and use both hands to flatten and spread out the blanket removing any wrinkles, and anchoring with belongings. There are a variety of beach blankets available on the market to accommodate both the aesthetic and utilitarian aspects desired by beach goers. As such, beach blankets come in a variety of different colors, designs, patterns, or dimensions. Whatever the appeal, young and old alike enjoy the pleasures and benefits of using beach blankets at beaches.

(3) The wide open sandy terrain of most beaches makes it conducive for exposure to high winds or wind gusts that swirl around uplifting blankets and sand in its path. The sand can create a lot of discomfort when trying to relax at the beach. It is welcomed when children enjoy themselves digging and building sand castles. However, the sand is not welcome when it intrudes onto a beach blanket creating discomfort from the gritty texture. Beachgoers typically have to remove their belongings, pick up the blanket, shake it to remove sand and then reposition the blanket back onto the sand. It is quite frustrating for users to consistently reposition the beach blanket over the sandy surface of the beach as a result of the wind or sand landing on the blanket. Individuals find themselves either fetching the blanket that has blown away from the resting site, or removing sand and repositioning the layout of the blanket. On windy days, it is common practice for beach goers to repeat this process over and over again constantly struggling to retain the blanket in place, and shaking off sand that has migrated onto the top surface of the blanket.

(4) Various devices and techniques have been employed to overcome the challenges beach goers face in securing their blankets on the sandy surface of the beach. A common practice often involves weighing down beach blankets with one or more objects. As such, individuals often place a weighted article along one or both sides of the blanket, or at the corners of the beach blanket to prevent the blanket from overturning as a result of wind or movement on the blanket. Individuals will often use a purse, toys, bottled drinks, a small cooler, leg of chair, or other article on a portion of the beach blanket to anchor the blanket down. Although the added weight may resolve the need for anchoring the blanket, the weight is insufficient to retain the blanket in a tensioned laid out position to permit easily removing sand from the top surface of the blanket. Additionally, beachgoers may also use their hands to manually scoop sand into a bag to anchor a blanket, which can often be very messy and time consuming.

(5) Various techniques have also been used in an effort to remove the sand from the body laying surface of blankets. Some beach goers try to brush the sand off with their hands by swiping their hands over the top of the blanket while trying to retain the flat, non-wrinkled, positional layout of the blanket. As the person swipes the sand off the blanket, the weights, used to anchor the blanket, move out of position resulting in the blanket bunching up with wrinkles making it difficult to remove the top sand and forcing the user to reposition both the weights, and the blanket. Some might try to remove the sand by way of ejection, but also fail due to insufficient anchoring and not having stretching capability causing it to wrinkle and become dispositioned. Typically, most beach goers shake and reposition the blanket repeatedly to remove the sand. A blanket having a sand-free benefit is of great interest for individual beach goers using suntan lotion or oils, as the moisture provides an attractant for sand to stick to the skin. So being able to quickly remove top sand, creating a sand-free sun bathing surface is of great value and makes the day at the beach more

enjoyable.

(6) Accordingly, there exists a need to solve at least one of the aforementioned problems mentioned herein, and to provide a beach blanket that is adequately anchored on a beach with ease, and provides opposing tension on the structural layout of the blanket for easily, quickly, and efficiently ejecting sand off the top surface of the blanket during use, while preventing the wind from uplifting and blowing the blanket away.

SUMMARY OF THE INVENTION

(7) The present invention is directed to an anchoring beach apparatus or beach blanket. More particularly, the invention relates to a beach apparatus including a plurality of pivotally attached bags that are designed for digging and scooping a ballast, such as sand on a beach, into each bag where the sand-filled bags are positioned in a spread-out formation on the beach to provide opposing tension on the main panel of the beach blanket to easily, quickly, and efficiently eject sand from the sunbathing surface of the blanket while securely anchoring the blanket on the beach to resist wind.

(8) A first embodiment of the invention provides a beach blanket comprising: a stretchable, main panel having opposite sides including a body supporting side and a bottom side, a plurality of invertible bags, each bag including a collapsible surrounding wall having a closed bottom, an open top defining a top perimeter and a cavity for removably holding a ballast, and a closure for closing the open top, and wherein a portion of each of the plurality of invertible bags is attached to the stretchable main panel to providing an articulated connection where each of the plurality of invertible bags pivots freely about the stretchable main panel to scoop ballast in the bags.

(9) In one aspect, the body supporting side, and the bottom side comprise either a single layer, or multiple layers of material.

(10) In one aspect, the stretchable main panel comprises a rectangular stretchable main panel having four corners, and a surrounding border.

(11) In another aspect, each portion of a first, a second, a third, and a fourth of said plurality of invertible bags is pivotally attached to the respective four corners of the rectangular stretchable main panel to provide an articulated connection in which each of the invertible bags rotate or pivots freely for scooping the ballast therein.

(12) In one aspect, each of the plurality of invertible bags is permanently, or removably pivotally attached to the four corners of the rectangular, stretchable main panel.

(13) In yet another aspect, the border is defined by lateral edges, and longitudinal edges, where an elastic member is separately enclosed within the border, or comprises an elastic material that is interwoven with the border, to allow the lateral and longitudinal edges of the stretchable main panel to resiliently expand and contract.

(14) In another aspect, the top perimeter, of each of the plurality of bags, includes a channel spanning the circumference of the top perimeter and includes at least one opening extending within the channel where the closure comprises a draw string enclosed within the channel and extending partially outwards from the at least one opening to openingly close the cavity. An optional spring-loaded lock may be provided with the drawstring.

(15) In yet another aspect, a portion of each of the plurality of invertible bags comprises a portion of the collapsible surrounding wall, a portion of the top perimeter, or both.

(16) In another aspect, each of the plurality of invertible bags includes a hand contact surface readily engaging inner surface areas of a user's hands, and a ballast contact surface engaging with the ballast when digging and scooping the ballast.

(17) In another aspect, the pair of straps includes a first strap and a second strap, each strap being attached to the collapsible surrounding wall. Also, the plurality of invertible bags may include a flap that is permanently or removably attached to, or adjacent the top perimeter, or to the collapsible surrounding wall to prevent the ballast from contacting a user's hands when scooping sand.

(18) In another aspect, any or all of each of the plurality of invertible bags includes a storage pouch having a closure for removably retaining items therein.

(19) These and other aspects, features, and advantages of the present invention will become more readily apparent from the attached drawings and the detailed description of the preferred embodiments, which follow.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

(1) The preferred embodiments of the invention will hereinafter be described in conjunction with the appended drawings provided to illustrate and not to limit the invention, where like designations denote like elements, and in which:

(2) FIG. 1 presents a top, perspective view of a beach blanket, showing a plurality of invertible bags attached to a stretchable main panel for scooping and holding a ballast such as beach sand, where each bag includes straps, a bottom strap, and a closure, in accordance with one embodiment of the present invention;

(3) FIG. 2 presents a bottom, perspective view of the beach blanket of FIG. 1, showing each of the plurality of invertible bags including an optional flap to prevent sand from coming into contact with a person's hands when scooping beach sand into the bag, in accordance with the embodiment of the present invention;

(4) FIG. 3 presents a cross-sectional view of one of the plurality of invertible bags of FIG. 1, showing a partial view of a channel enclosing a draw string used for closing the opening a cavity retaining beach sand, and a storage pouch for storing a variety of items, in accordance with an embodiment of the present invention;

(5) FIG. 4 presents an operative, perspective view of the beach blanket of FIG. 1, readily disposed on a sandy surface of a beach represented as a block portion, each of the plurality of invertible bags readily positioned for digging and scooping sand therein, in accordance with the embodiment of the present invention;

(6) FIG. 5 presents a schematic, partial view of a user's hands positioned over one of the plurality of invertible bags, showing readily sliding both hands into an inverted bag to dig sand into a pile and revert the bag to scoop in a large quantity of sand within the bag, and closing the bag with the draw string, in accordance with an embodiment of the present invention;

(7) FIG. 6 presents a side, perspective view, of the beach blanket of FIG. 4, showing each sand-filled bag displaced outward on the beach to provide opposing tension on the blanket by expanding the stretchable main panel in a non-wrinkled, stretched out manner to easily propel sand off the blanket, in accordance with an embodiment of the present invention; and

(8) FIG. 7 presents an isometric view of one bag of FIG. 1, showing the stretchable main panel and three of the invertible bags removably stored within one of the plurality of invertible bags for easily carrying and transporting the beach blanket, in accordance with an embodiment of the present invention.

(9) FIG. 8 presents a top, perspective view of a beach blanket, showing a plurality of invertible bags attached to a stretchable main panel for scooping and holding a ballast such as beach sand, where each bag includes straps, a bottom strap, a closure, and a plurality of hand sleeves in accordance with one embodiment of the present invention.

(10) FIG. 9 presents a cross-sectional view of one of the plurality of invertible bags of FIG. 8, showing a partial view of a channel enclosing a draw string used for closing the opening a cavity retaining beach sand, a storage pouch for storing a variety of items, and the hand sleeves configured to allow a user to scoop sand into the cavity, in accordance with an embodiment of the present invention; and

(11) FIG. 10 presents a schematic, partial view of a user's hands positioned over one of the plurality of invertible bags, showing readily sliding both hands into the plurality of hand sleeves, one on each side of the bag, such that the cavity of the inverted bag is used to dig sand into a pile and revert the bag to scoop in a large quantity of sand within the bag, and closing the bag with the draw string, in accordance with an embodiment of the present invention.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

(12) The following detailed description is merely exemplary in nature and is not intended to limit the described embodiments or the application and uses of the described embodiments. As used herein, the word “exemplary” or “illustrative” means “serving as an example, instance, or illustration.” Any implementation described herein as “exemplary” or “illustrative” is not necessarily to be construed as preferred or advantageous over other implementations. All of the implementations described below are exemplary implementations provided to enable persons skilled in the art to make or use the embodiments of the disclosure and are not intended to limit the scope of the disclosure, which is defined by the claims. For purposes of description herein, the terms “upper”, “lower”, “left”, “rear”, “right”, “front”, “back”, “vertical”, “horizontal”, and derivatives thereof shall relate to the invention as oriented in FIG. 1. Furthermore, there is no intention to be bound by any expressed or implied theory presented in the preceding technical field, background, brief summary or the following detailed description. It is also to be understood that the specific devices and processes illustrated in the attached drawings, and described in the following specification, are simply exemplary embodiments of the inventive concepts defined in the appended claims. Hence, specific dimensions and other physical characteristics relating to the embodiments disclosed herein are not to be considered as limiting, unless the claims expressly state otherwise.

(13) Shown throughout the figures, the present invention is directed to a beach blanket including a stretchable main panel having opposite sides comprising a body supporting side for individuals to lay on, and a bottom side to rest on the sandy beach, and a plurality of invertible bags each pivotally attached to the corners of the stretchable main panel, and used to dig, scoop and hold sand therein. The sand-filled bags are displaced outwards to provide opposing tension on the stretchable main panel, for easily, quickly, and efficiently ejecting sand off the top layer of the blanket, and for anchoring the beach blanket on a beach to prevent wind from blowing away the blanket.

(14) Referring now to the figures wherein like numerals are represented by like elements throughout, there are shown in FIGS. 1 and 2 a top, and a bottom perspective view, respectively, of a beach blanket **100** including a stretchable main panel **102**, and a plurality of invertible bags **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** attached at various positions along the peripheral edge, border, or outer perimeter **112** of the stretchable main panel **102**, in accordance with one embodiment of the present invention. It is appreciated that reference herein is made to various terms throughout the description including the terms, beach and sand. It will be understood that the term, “beach” as used herein not only refers to and includes the ordinary meaning of term relating to any and all areas designated for recreational use associated with oceans, but also includes areas found in close proximity to streams, ponds, lakes, or rivers including coastland, lakeshore, seacoast, or riverside, to name a few. Also, the term, “sand” as used herein, may include any and all natural or artificial sand, small rocks, pebbles, stones, dirt, granules, soil, fill, gravel, or any other ballast amendable for removable storage within each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, and **110**.

(15) The stretchable main panel, generally denoted at **102**, comprises two opposite sides including a body supporting side **114** designated as a laying surface for individuals to lay on, and a bottom side **116** for placement on a sandy surface of a beach. In one preferred embodiment, the stretchable main panel **102** comprises a generally rectangular geometric shape dimensioned to accommodate the overall length of a human body, and includes lateral and longitudinal borders **112** intersecting perpendicular at four corners of the rectangular panel. The dimensional configuration of the stretchable main panel **102** is selected to accommodate use by any number of individuals, and as

such, may comprise any dimensional length and/or width. For example, the stretchable main panel **102** may be designed for use by a single person, a couple, or made large enough to accommodate a family. The stretchable main panel **102** may comprise other geometrical shapes and dimensions including a round, triangular, oval, or square shape. While at the beach, individuals are typically dressed for the occasion of sunbathing, or swimming, thus exposing a greater area of skin. Since the exposed skin will likely come into contact with the top side **114** of the stretchable main panel **102** when the person is laying on the beach blanket **100**, it is contemplated that the top side **114** comprise a soft fabric, textile, or cloth material that will not irritate the user's skin. As such, the top side **114** may comprise a soft, woven or non-woven, synthetic or non-synthetic fabric, textile, or cloth material including, but not limited to, a terry cloth, a French cloth, micro-fibers, cotton, polyester, chiffon, or any combination thereof. The top side **114** may comprise a single layer, or multiple layers of fabric, cloth or textiles that comprise the same or different material. In one embodiment, the top side **114** comprises a single layer having absorbent properties adapted for soaking up liquid or moisture. Alternatively, the top side **114** may comprise a first layer that is permanently or releasably attached to a second layer having impermeable or absorbent characteristics allowing moisture to pass through the first layer and flow down to the second layer thus keeping the first layer dry. Also, in one non-limiting embodiment, the first layer may be removably attached to the second layer using any well-known fastener allowing users to remove the first layer for washing, repair or replacement. In one embodiment, the bottom side **116** may comprise an impermeable, non-absorbent material to prevent moisture from reaching the top side **114** causing discomfort to users. As such, the bottom side **116** may comprise a nylon material to prevent sand from sticking to its surface, a laminated fabric, a woven or non-woven fabric treated with a water-repellant or cooling chemical, or simply entail the same fabric material used in constructing the top side **114**, keeping with the purview that the stretchable main panel **102** be machine washable. It will be appreciated that the stretchable main panel **102** may comprise a wide range of stretchability in which users can pinch any portion of the panel and pluck the panel to spring and propel any sand on the panel away from the top side **114**. In one preferred embodiment, the main panel **102** comprises a single layer of material comprising a knitted fabric or cloth, such as a stretchable terry cloth having a soft upper surface. The main panel **102** may include water-resistant or water-repellant properties.

(16) With continued reference to FIGS. **1** and **2**, a variation of the stretchable main panel **102** may include a border **112** that incorporates elastic properties in which the border **112** resiliently stretches or expands in length in conjunction with the stretching material of the stretchable main panel **102**. For this reason, the border **112** may incorporate one or more elastic members or a stretchable material. In one embodiment, a section of the stretchable main panel **102** may be folded over an elastic member where a peripheral edge of the folded section is sewn along a seam, depicted at **118**. The section of the stretchable main panel **102**, or the elastic member itself may comprise spandex, lycra, or any other stretchable material. The combinational, functional aspect of the elastic member(s) and stretchable main panel **102** permits readily stretching or spreading out, the stretchable main panel **102** when displacing the positional layout of the sand-filled bags **104**, **106**, **108**, and **110**. The incorporated elastic member generally spans the length of each lateral and longitudinal border **112** in a rectangular body, and may include a single member, or separate and distinct members, strands, or fibers that are selectively attached together at designated points via, stitching or gluing. The elastic member can be interwoven within the border in one alternative embodiment. Also, because the beach blanket **100** is likely exposed to high temperatures of the sun, and to salt from ocean water, the border **112** or elastic member may be coated with a protective material, or comprise water-resistance properties. The elastic member may comprise a resilient rubber material, or a combination of fabric and rubber materials. The material attached to the elastic member may be bunched up, or gathered together where the material extends flat when the elastic member is stretched to capacity. It will be appreciated that in embodiments where the

stretchable main panel **102** comprises a round, oval or other geometrical shape, the border **112** as used in such configurations may also comprise or incorporate a resilient, stretchable material or member.

(17) With continued reference to FIGS. **1** and **2**, the beach blanket **100** includes a plurality of invertible bags **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** shown openly expanded in preparation for use. Each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** is configured to dig, scoop and store a large amount of sand that is used as a ballast to securely anchor the pockets and beach blanket **100** on the sandy surface of a beach. Each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** generally includes a single panel, or multiple panels that are sewn together, to define a receptacle having a collapsible surrounding wall **120**, a closed bottom **122**, and a top opening **124** having an opening perimeter **126**, as better illustrated in relation to bag **104** in FIG. **2**. Each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** may be constructed from the same or different material used to construct the stretchable main panel **102**. In one embodiment, each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** is constructed from a nylon material to prevent sand from sticking onto the surface of the sidewall **120** allowing sand to slide freely or exit freely out from the bags **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** when emptying the sand from the bags. Each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** comprises any of a semi-oval, semi-circular, triangular shape, or semi-ellipse shape or configuration, or any combination thereof, that permits digging, scooping, and storing a large quantity of sand therein.

(18) An exemplified feature of the beach blanket **100** includes the ability for each invertible bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** to pivot or articulate about the corner regions of the stretchable main panel **102** with ease and efficiency. The articulated motion of each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** allows users to easily maneuver, and manipulate each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** when inserting each bag into the sandy beach to dig and scoop in sand. The articulated connection is defined by a portion of the collapsible surrounding wall **120**, or a portion adjacent to, or comprising, the perimeter **126** of the top opening **124**, of each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** being attached to respective corner regions of the stretchable main panel **102**. In one example, the corner regions of the main panel **102** are each joined to a section or portion of the opening perimeter **126** of each bag **104** by sewing or stitching, defining a seam, denoted at **128**. The seam **128** provides a hinge mechanism, or articulated connection, that permits each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** to rotate or pivot freely about the corners of the stretchable main panel **102** generally greater than 350-degree angle of rotation. The articulated motion of each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** provided by the seam **128**, allows users to easily manipulate, position, and insert the bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** into the sandy beach to dig and scoop in sand, and to easily remove sand from each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** with ease and efficiency. In one non-limiting embodiment, each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** may be permanently or removably attached to the corners or corner regions of the stretchable main panel **102** using a variety of well-known stitching processes or fasteners that permit removeable attachment of the bags **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** to the corners of the stretchable main panel **102**. For example, fasteners such as snaps, magnets, buttons, zippers, or clips would allow users to removably attach each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** to the corner regions of the stretchable main panel **102** to permit replacement, repair, or the ability to rinse or wash the bags **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** after use. Male/female connections may be provided on each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** and respective corners of the stretchable main panel **102**. It will be understood that in one non-limiting embodiment, each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** may be integrally formed with the stretchable main panel **102** thus eliminating the need for employing a separate process of sewing to stitching each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** to the corners of the stretchable main panel **102**.

(19) With continued reference to FIGS. **1** and **2**, each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** includes a pair of straps **130**, **132** extending from the collapsible surrounding wall **120**, and a bottom strap **134** attached to the bottom **122** surface area. In one exemplary embodiment, the straps **130**, **132** each comprise loops that are formed by folding a strap and stitching the ends of the strap together on the surface of the wall **120** of each bag. The straps **130**, **132** are employed to assist users in effectively emptying sand from each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** after use. Each bag also includes a bottom strap

134 in which distal ends of the bottom strap **134** are sewn to the bottom **122**. Each bottom strap **134** is used for repositioning the bags to increase tension after being filled with sand, and to empty the sand from the bags when lifted after opening it by using the straps **130**, and **132**. It will be appreciated that the straps **130**, **132**, and bottom straps **134**, of each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110**, may be permanently or removably attached using well-known fasteners rather than by a process of sewing or stitching. For example, such fasteners may include snaps, buttons, Velcro™, or clips. Also, bottom strap **134** may comprise a single strap or two separate and distinct straps designated for each thumb of the right and left hand of users. The bottom straps **134** may also comprise a stretchable material that permits users to expand their hands further apart from one another when the hands are positioned on the bags **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** to scoop sand.

(20) In one, non-limiting embodiment, each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** may optionally include a flap **136**, **138**, **140**, **142**, as better illustrated in FIG. 2, to prevent sand from coming into contact with the user's hands when digging and scooping sand. Each flap **136**, **138**, **140**, **142** comprises generally a rectangular, semi-circular, semi-oval, or semi-elliptical shape, having a lateral edge and an arcuate edge. The lateral edge of each flap is affixed along the opening perimeter **126**, as shown with bag **104** in FIG. 2, and an arcuate edge extending towards the bottom end **122**. Each flap **136**, **138**, **140**, **142** may comprise the same or different materials used to construct bag **104**, **106**, **108** and **110**, and may include one or more fasteners in which users can easily attach or remove each flap from respective bags if desired. Such fasteners may include a zipper, snaps, buttons, Velcro™, magnets, or clips. Each flap **136**, **138**, **140**, **142** may comprise a single piece that encircles the circumference of each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110**, or comprise any number of separate and distinct pieces. It will be appreciated that in one embodiment, the beach blanket **100** may include bags **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** having permanently or removably attached flaps, or having no bag flaps at all. Thus, bag flaps **136**, **138**, **140**, **142** may be provided as an optional feature to use with the beach blanket **100**.

(21) Turning now to FIG. 3 there is shown a cross-sectional view of one bag, denoted at **104**, showing a partial view of an opening perimeter **126** having a channel **144** adapted for enclosing a draw string **146** therein to operatively constrict or close the perimeter **126** and opening of the bag **104** thereby enclosing sand therein. The bag **104** further includes a storage pouch **156** for storing a variety of items or articles typically used while at the beach. It is noted that for illustrative purposes and without limitation, description made regarding functional and constructional features of bag **104**, is also applicable to bags **106**, **108** and **110** as well. Each opening perimeter **126** of each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** includes a channel **144** sized and dimensioned to operatively enclose a draw string **146** having a predetermined length. A spring-loaded cord lock **150** is provided to tighten the draw string **146** to retain the perimeter opening **126** closed. The spring-loaded lock **150** comprises any well-known cord lock typically used for selectively adjusting the length of cords or ropes. The draw string **146** may comprise a cotton, or nylon string or rope having a predetermined diameter and length associated with the size and dimension of the channel **144**, and the circumference of each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, and **110**. Each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** includes a drawing string **146**, **148**, **152**, **154**, to close each individual bag, as better illustrated in FIG. 1. It is appreciated that an elastic member or stretchable material may be incorporated within the opening perimeter **126** of one or more bags **104**, **106**, **108**, and **110**. One or more bags **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** includes a storage pouch **156** incorporated within or provided on, the sidewall **120** of each bag and sized to store a variety of different items therein, including, but not limited to, keys, cell phone, wallet, money, jewelry, earbuds, CD's, food, drinks, an articles of clothing, or other items typically used by beach goers. A pouch closure **158** comprising any of a zipper, snaps, magnets, buckles, buttons, or the like is employed to securely close the opening of the storage pouch **156** to securely retain the items therein.

(22) With reference now made to FIG. 4 there is shown an operative, perspective view of the beach blanket **100** of FIG. 1, readily disposed on the sandy surface of a beach **200** generally represented

as a block section of a beach, in accordance with the embodiment of the present invention. Upon selecting a designated resting area on the beach **200**, users spread out the beach blanket **100** on the sandy surface of the beach **200** with the bottom side **116** of the stretchable main panel **102** laid to rest on the sandy surface, as shown by directional arrows. Each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** is laid out from respective corners of the stretchable main panel **102** onto the sandy surface. Once properly situated, users begin filling each individual bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** with sand by digging and scooping the sand with the bag.

(23) As illustrated in FIG. 5, each bag **104** is used to dig and scoop a large quantity of sand with the bag **104** without the use of tools. The bags **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** are filled with sand using the same technique, process, or method as exemplified in FIG. 5. Upon laying the beach blanket **100** in the desired location on the beach, users begin filling each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** with sand, by situating themselves in front of the open part of the bag to be filled. Users reach out and place both hands onto the non-inverted portion of the sidewall **120** and spread away from each other to tension the bottom of the bag. The inner surface of each hand including the phalanges of the fingers lay flat against the sidewall **120** material of the bag **104** and the user, using the inner surface of the hand, and the distal end of the fingers, applies a downward, scooping motion forcing a portion of the bag **104** into the sand digging and scooping a large amount of sand into a pile. The bag **104** is then reverted and while doing so, the pile of sand is scooped up into the bag **104**. Another feature configured to assist in the scooping of sand into the bag **104** may be a plurality of hand sleeves **135** found on bag **104**, as best shown in FIG. 8. As shown in FIG. 8, the plurality of hand sleeves **135** may be found on each side of the bag **104** or on some exterior portion of the bag **104**. In the present embodiment, the plurality of hand sleeves **135** may be two, one for each hand of the user. Instead of the user placing in the non-inverted portion of the sidewall **120**, a user may place each hand into each of the plurality of hand sleeves **135** and then apply the same downward scooping motion to allow the bag **104** to fill with sand. Upon filling the bag **104** with sand, the user pulls the draw string **146** to forcibly constrict the opening perimeter **126** of the bag **104** and operates the spring-loaded lock **150** to close the opening **124**, shown in FIG. 2, to retain the scooped sand within the bag **104**. This process is repeated until all bags **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** are filled with sand. The constructional semi-oval, or semi-ellipse shape of each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** permits a large amount of sand to be easily scooped and enclosed within the cavity of each bag by a user's hands without having to use tools. The larger sized bags **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** hold more sand to provide heavier or greater weight at the corners of the main panel **102** thus maintaining opposed tension on the main panel **102** and preventing the main panel **102** from bunching, or wrinkling when users remove by ejecting sand off the top side **114**. FIG. 9 demonstrates how the bag **104** collapses when not in use.

(24) Upon filling each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** with sand, users displace or position each sand-filled bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** outwards, in a spaced-apart relation with one another, on the beach **200**, to stretch the main panel **102** and elastic members enclosed within the border **112** in a non-wrinkled, stretched out fashion to provide opposing tension on the top laying surface of the beach blanket. Sand migrating onto the top laying surface is easily and quickly ejected off the surface, by simply pinching a small section of the stretchable main panel **102** between two fingers, lifting the portion section and releasing the section to eject, or propel any sand off the blanket. The displaced weight of the sand-filled bags **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** provides opposing tension to expand the stretchable material of the main panel **102** allowing users to easily pluck the main panel **102** to spring and propel sand off the top side **114**.

(25) Once the beach blanket **100** is properly anchored for use on the beach **200**, users can also store any number of items in one or more storage pouches **156** provided on one or more bags **104**, **106**, **108** and **110**, as shown in FIG. 3. Each storage pouch **156** may comprise multiple compartments, each dimensionally sized to store designated items, or any number of different items including for example, keys, wallet, food, drinks, bottles, containers, utensils, cell phone, cosmetics, hair brush

and other items.

(26) When getting ready to leave the beach for the day, users loosen each spring-loaded lock **150**, of each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** to extend respective draw strings **146**, **148**, **152**, **154**, as shown in FIG. 4, and remove the sand from each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, and **110**. Users can use the assistance of the straps **130**, **132** to force sand out. Once sand is fully removed from each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110**, the stretchable main panel **102**, and three of the emptied bags **106**, **108**, **110** are folded and stuffed into a designated storage bag **104**, as illustrated in FIG. 7. A carrying strap **160** is provided on the outer surface of the sidewall **120** of the bag **104** for carrying and transporting the beach blanket **100** from place to place. The draw string **146** can be used to constrict the opening perimeter **126** and the spring-loaded lock **150** operated to securely retain the stretchable main panel **102** and emptied bags **106**, **108**, **110** within the designated storage bag **104**. It is appreciated that any bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** may be used as the designated storage bag, or alternatively, one bag may be selected and configured as the designated storage bag.

(27) It is appreciated that several optional features may be employed or incorporated with the beach blanket **100** without departing from the scope of the invention. For example, the beach blanket **100** may include an inflatable or plush-filled pillow that is permanently, or removably attached to the stretchable main panel **102** to rest a user's head on when laying on the blanket. A series of grommets may be provided anywhere along the border **112** for attaching articles to the blanket **100**. Also, fasteners may be provided on the top side **114** of the stretchable main panel **102** to removably attach a blanket for covering the person laying on the blanket **100**. Although the bags **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** are shown attached to the four corners of the stretchable main panel **102**, it is also contemplated that the bags **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** can be attached anywhere along the perimeter of the stretchable main panel **102** without compromising the functional attributes of anchoring the beach blanket **100**. Also the plurality of bags **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** may comprise any number of bags. One or more storage pouches may be permanently, or removably, provided or attached anywhere on the top side **114** of the stretchable main panel **102**. Also, each bag **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** may include indicia or markings provided on the surface of the sidewall **120** to indicate where and/or how to position the user's hand when using the bags **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** to scoop sand. For example, indicia or markings representing the imprint or boundary lines of a hand can be provided on any or all bags **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** using any well-known printing, sewing, embossing, or painting technique or process. The beach blanket **100** may exhibit a certain aesthetic appeal where the stretchable main panel **102** comprises a particular motif, silhouette of an animal, insect, or fish, incorporate a sports team logo or mascot, and include indicia comprising words, letters, numbers, characters, symbols, quotes, photos, patterns or designs. Additionally, as best shown in FIG. 8, any or all bags **104**, **106**, **108**, **110** may be equipped with speakers **137** and Bluetooth such that music may be played from an external device such as a phone or tablet.

(28) While the preferred embodiments of the invention have been described above, it will be recognized and understood that various modifications can be made in the invention and the appended claims are intended to cover all such modifications, which may fall within the spirit and scope of the invention.

Claims

1. A beach apparatus comprising: a stretchable main panel; a plurality of bags, each bag including: a collapsible surrounding wall defining a cavity for removably holding a ballast, and a plurality of hand sleeves disposed on the collapsible surrounding wall; wherein each of the plurality of hand sleeves is configured to receive a hand of a user and to allow the user to manipulate a bag of the plurality of bags to scoop the ballast into the cavity; wherein the cavity of each bag has a first volume configured to retain a quantity of the scooped ballast greater than a second volume defined by each one of the hand sleeves; and wherein a portion of each of the plurality of bags is attached

- to a corner of the stretchable main panel to provide an articulated connection that permits the bag of the plurality of bags to pivot relative to the stretchable main panel during scooping.
2. The beach apparatus of claim 1, wherein the stretchable main panel has opposite sides having a body supporting atop side and a bottom side.
 3. The beach apparatus of claim 2, wherein said body supporting said top side and said bottom side each comprise either a single layer or multiple layers.
 4. The beach apparatus of claim 2, wherein said body supporting said top side comprises a soft fabric material.
 5. The beach apparatus of claim 4, wherein said soft fabric material is at least one of water repellant and self-cooling.
 6. The beach apparatus of claim 1, wherein at least one of said plurality of bags includes a speaker.
 7. The beach apparatus of claim 1, wherein each of said plurality of bags includes a hand contact surface readily engaging an inner surface area of the hands of the user to scoop said ballast, and a ballast contact surface engaging with said ballast.
 8. The beach apparatus of claim 1, wherein said stretchable main panel comprises a rectangular stretchable main panel having four corners.
 9. The beach apparatus of claim 1, wherein said portion of each of said plurality of bags, is attached to respective four corners of said rectangular stretchable main panel.
 10. The beach apparatus of claim 8, wherein said portion comprises a section of said collapsible surrounding wall, or a section of a top perimeter, of each bag, said section of either said collapsible surrounding wall or said top perimeter attached to said corners by stitching.
 11. The beach apparatus of claim 1, wherein said stretchable main panel includes a border having an elastic member, said border defining a pair of lateral edges and a pair of longitudinal edges, said elastic member permitting said pair of lateral edges and said pair of longitudinal edges to resiliently expand and contract.
 12. The beach apparatus of claim 9, wherein each of said plurality of bags includes a pair of straps attached to said collapsible surrounding wall, and a bottom strap having opposite ends attached to said closed bottom.
 13. The beach apparatus of claim 12, wherein said pair of straps includes a first strap and a second strap each attached to said collapsible surrounding wall.
 14. The beach apparatus of claim 1, wherein any or all of each of said plurality of bags includes a storage pouch provided on said collapsible surrounding wall and including a closure.
 15. The beach apparatus of claim 14, wherein said storage pouch is accessible to store items therein when any or all of each of said plurality of bags are filled with said ballast and positioned to anchor said stretchable main panel.
 16. The beach apparatus of claim 14, wherein said storage pouch is configured to comprise multiple compartments.
 17. The beach apparatus of claim 16, wherein said stretchable main panel, and at least three of said plurality of bags are removably stored within one of said plurality of bags.
 18. The beach apparatus of claim 11, wherein said elastic member comprises either an elastic band separately enclosed within said border, or an elastic material that is interwoven with said border.
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